Another significant message was the importance of cooperatives in linking Indian farmers with global markets and ensuring profits flow directly into their bank accounts. Partnering with National Cooperative Exports Ltd and National Cooperative Organics Ltd, and promoting certified organic products under the 'Bharat Organic' brand, NAFED is showing the way forward for value-driven and farmer-centric marketing models.

Q. How is NAFED leveraging digital and technological innovations to serve farmers and cooperatives better?

A. Digital transformation is at the core of NAFED's modernization agenda. We have computerized our procurement, storage, and distribution operations, making transactions more transparent and efficient. The NAFED App, for example, now facilitates direct farmer registrations and enables us to plan procurements with unprecedented precision. Further, we support cooperative capacity-building by introducing AI-driven advisory services, promoting best practices in production and logistics, and facilitating digital marketing of agricultural products. With the integration of supply chain management tools, online order platforms, and real-time pricing updates, cooperatives and FPOs can respond quickly to market shifts, optimize storage/commercial logistics, and minimize food wastage.

Q. What new initiatives or collaborations has NAFED launched recently to further its mission?

A. Among our most notable recent initiatives is the expansion of the Bharat Brand Products under the Open Market Sale Scheme (OMSS), ensuring affordable pricing for staples such as rice, atta, pulses, and more throughout India. International collaborations are another frontier. At Gulfood 2025 in Dubai, we signed an MoU with Lulu Group, enabling NAFED products to be stocked in retail stores worldwide, a significant move for Indian farmers seeking global markets.

We have also successfully conducted national debates, quizzes, and capacity-building programs to mark the International Year of Cooperatives, planting the seeds of cooperative spirit among youth and stakeholders. In terms of capacity development, we systematically send senior management to premier institutions like IIM Ahmedabad and ASCI Hyderabad, ensuring world-class training in cooperative management for our future leaders.





We also conduct study tours to expose students and cooperative leaders to best practices in agricultural marketing, supply chain management, and technological innovation.

Q. NAFED is seen as a torchbearer for sustainability and social impact in Indian agriculture. Could you elaborate on your role here?

A. Sustainability is at the heart of what we do at NAFED. Our focus on procuring, processing, and marketing pulses, oilseeds, and organic products naturally promotes better farming practices and crop diversification across the country.

We've significantly expanded our certified seed minikit distribution program for pulses and oilseeds. By subsidizing these input costs for farmers, we're not only helping them achieve better yields but also contributing to improved soil health. Our biofertilizer division has gained national recognition for both productivity and environmental benefits, helping farmers reduce their dependence on chemical inputs while building healthier soils.

One area where we make a real difference is tackling food wastage. Through reliable storage facilities and market stabilization efforts, we help minimize post-harvest losses. This creates a win-win situation: farmers face fewer economic losses, and we reduce the environmental impact that comes from food spoilage.

We're also leveraging digital platforms to directly connect with farming communities. Our social media outreach keeps farmers, women, and rural youth informed about government schemes, market opportunities, and proven agricultural practices. This direct communication helps bridge the information gap that often exists in rural areas.

Q. What is your long-term vision for NAFED, especially as India celebrates the International Year of Cooperatives in 2025?

A. We have an ambitious but realistic vision for NAFED: to become a globally recognized institution that leads in cooperative marketing, farmer empowerment, and sustainable agriculture. Our goal is to ensure that every farmer, FPO, and cooperative across India can access organized markets and benefit from value-added processing and export opportunities.

Looking ahead to Vikasit Bharat @ 2047, aligned with the government's broader vision, we want to build a cooperative ecosystem that contributes significantly to India's GDP while creating meaningful livelihoods for millions in rural areas. This isn't just about economic growth; it's about transforming rural India.

The International Year of Cooperatives in 2025 represents a pivotal moment for us. We view it as our chance to strengthen the cooperative movement nationwide, extend NAFED's presence to every panchayat, and foster entrepreneurship among women and youth. We're particularly focused on driving innovation in agribusiness and positioning cooperatives as key drivers of India's journey toward self-reliance.

This year gives us the platform to demonstrate how cooperatives can be engines of both economic development and social change. We're not just talking about market access; we're talking about empowering entire communities.

Q. What message would you like to share with young professionals and future leaders interested in the cooperative sector?

A. The cooperative sector is at a turning point, offering immense potential for social impact, innovation, and leadership. My advice to young professionals: be bold, adopt technology, and remain committed to the values of collective progress and mutual support. Through cooperatives, you can help millions of farmers, transform rural livelihoods, and contribute to building a robust and equitable agricultural economy for India.NAFED will continue to open doors for innovation and collaboration. We welcome young leaders to join us in this journey, as we build on our proud legacy and chart a new, resilient future for Indian agriculture.

